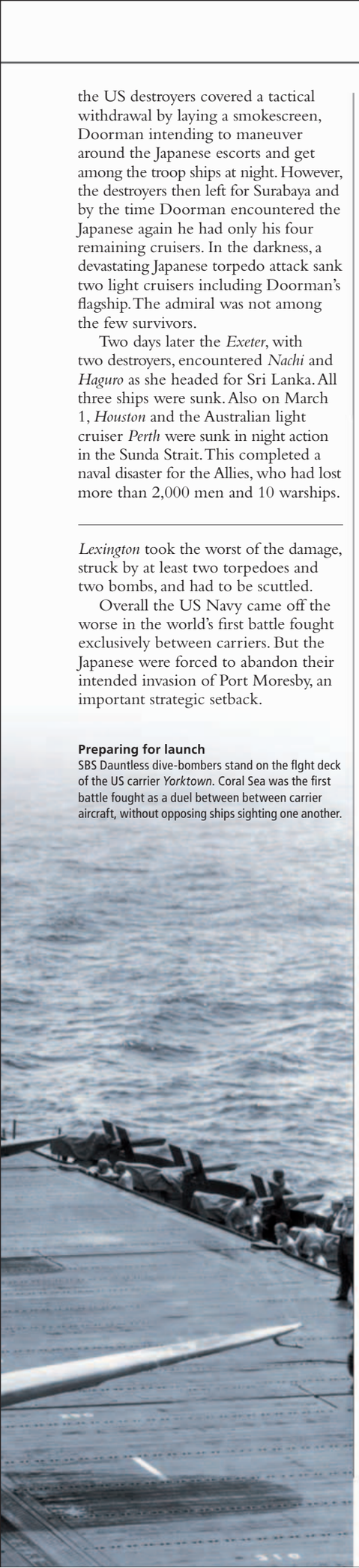
the US destroyers covered a tactical withdrawal by laying a smokescreen, Doorman intending to maneuver around the Japanese escorts and get among the troop ships at night. However, the destroyers then left for Surabaya and by the time Doorman encountered the Japanese again he had only his four remaining cruisers. In the darkness, a devastating Japanese torpedo attack sank two light cruisers including Doorman's flagship. The admiral was not among the few survivors.

Two days later the *Exeter*, with two destroyers, encountered *Nachi* and *Haguro* as she headed for Sri Lanka. All three ships were sunk. Also on March 1, *Houston* and the Australian light cruiser *Perth* were sunk in night action in the Sunda Strait. This completed a naval disaster for the Allies, who had lost more than 2,000 men and 10 warships.

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*Lexington* took the worst of the damage, struck by at least two torpedoes and two bombs, and had to be scuttled.

Overall the US Navy came off the worse in the world's first battle fought exclusively between carriers. But the Japanese were forced to abandon their intended invasion of Port Moresby, an important strategic setback.



**Preparing for launch**
SBS Dauntless dive-bombers stand on the flght deck of the US carrier *Yorktown*. Coral Sea was the first battle fought as a duel between between carrier aircraft, without opposing ships sighting one another.

CREW PROFILE

# US AIRCRAFT CARRIER

WORLD WAR II

WITH A CREW NUMBERING OVER 2,000 men, a World War II American fleet aircraft carrier was a complex social world, in which divisions of function were often as important as differences of rank. Some officers and men executed tasks required on all warships, while others did jobs specific to the business of operating warplanes from carriers. These included the aviation machinists and electricians who serviced the aircraft in the hangars, the aviation ordnance teams responsible for arming the planes, the aviation boatswain's mates whose tasks included supervising the catapults and arresting gear on the flight deck, and the landing signal officer—usually a trained aviator—who stood prominently on deck using colored paddles to guide pilots attempting to land. Until 1943 the navy accepted no draftees, so all crew members were volunteers, many going to sea to avoid being drafted into the army.

## NAVAL AVIATOR

American naval pilots were a gung-ho body of men, eager to fight and justly proud of their skills. Between 1942 and 1944 more than 50,000 were trained, most passing through Naval Air Station Pensacola in Florida. Officers became Naval Aviators while enlisted men were designated Naval Aviation Pilots (NAPs). On flying operations rank was disregarded, the most experienced fliers taking command even if this meant non-commissioned men giving orders to officers. As in all aerial warfare, a few pilots proved exceptionally gifted and these men led from the front. In fighter squadrons pilots flew in divisions of four aircraft. The leader of the division was the man expected to shoot down enemy aircraft, the other three were there primarily to cover his back. A carrier pilot's task was exceptionally demanding because of the need to launch from and land on a small pitching flight deck crowded with aircraft. Taking off even with the aid of a catapult was only possible if the carrier was making speed into the wind. Landing posed even more complex problems. Once the pilot got "into the groove" to land, he was in the hands of the landing officer who would give him "the cut" to authorize landing or the "wave off" if all was not well. Pilots tended to be competitive individualists by nature, but they acknowledged that they needed the help and support of many other crew members to stay operational.



**Navy cadet**
A US Navy pilot climbs into the cockpit of a gleaming T-6 Texan trainer aircraft during flight training at Naval Air Station Corpus Christi in Texas in 1942.



**Pilot briefing**
The commanding officer of Fighting Squadron 16 briefs his pilots in front of an F6F-3 Hellcat fighter on board the USS *Lexington* in 1943.